In Every World, But This One

Scene 1.

The cold iron of the bench on Platform 3 pressed against Riven's back through his coat, but he barely noticed anymore. He had been sitting there long enough for the discomfort to become familiar, like an old scar that only reminded you of itself when the weather changed.

Midnight had settled over the station hours ago. The ticket counters were closed, their metal shutters pulled down with the finality of a shopkeeper ending a long day. A discarded newspaper lay trapped beneath a bench farther down the platform, its corner fluttering occasionally whenever the wind found its way through the station. Above him, a fluorescent bulb hummed softly. Every few seconds it flickered, not enough to go dark, just enough to make a person wonder if it might.

Riven checked his watch.

12:04 AM.

The gesture was pointless. He already knew the time. He had checked less than a minute ago.

The last train had left two hours earlier.

He had watched it leave.

The engine had rumbled to life, the doors had slid shut, and one by one the carriages had disappeared into the darkness beyond the station. He still remembered the red taillights shrinking into the distance until they looked like two tiny stars before finally vanishing altogether.

Most people would have gone home after that.

Riven stayed.

A train horn echoed somewhere far away. The sound drifted through the sleeping city before fading into silence. It wasn't coming here. There were no more arrivals scheduled tonight. Even the digital display board hanging above the platform had given up pretending otherwise and simply displayed the time.

12:04.

12:05.

12:06.

The numbers changed. Nothing else did.

Riven slipped a hand into his coat pocket and pulled out an old train ticket. The paper had become soft around the edges from years of being unfolded and folded again. A small tear had appeared near one corner. He ran his thumb across it absentmindedly while staring at the tracks.

He couldn't remember how many times he had looked at that ticket.

Enough.

Not enough.

The answer depended on the day.

A gust of wind swept through the station carrying the faint smell of rain. The sky above was hidden behind thick clouds, but the air had that familiar heaviness that came before a storm. Somewhere near the entrance, a loose metal sign rattled briefly before settling again.

Waiting had become a habit long ago.

At first it had felt temporary, something he would stop doing once he got the answer he wanted. Then months passed. Then years. Somewhere along the way, the waiting itself became part of him.

The strange thing was that he wasn't entirely sure what he was waiting for anymore.

A person.

A memory.

An explanation.

Some days those felt like the same thing.

His eyes drifted back to the ticket. The date printed across it had faded slightly, but he could still read it without difficulty. He had memorized every detail years ago. The train number. The departure time. Even the tiny coffee stain near the bottom corner.

Mira had laughed when she spilled it.

The memory arrived suddenly.

A paper cup.

Sunlight through a train window.

A silver ring turning slowly around a finger.

Her laughter.

Then it was gone.

Riven closed his eyes for a moment and exhaled slowly.

That happened more often these days. Memories appeared like visitors who refused to stay long enough for a proper conversation. They arrived, made a mess of everything, then disappeared before he could ask them why they had come.

When he opened his eyes again, the station remained exactly the same. Empty tracks. Flickering lights. The distant hum of electricity. Somewhere beyond the station walls, a motorcycle passed along a nearby road, its engine fading into the night.

The world continued moving.

He remained here.

A few drops of rain struck the platform roof overhead.

Then stopped.

A false alarm.

The clouds were teasing the city.

Riven leaned forward, resting his elbows on his knees. Across from him, a vending machine glowed faintly in the darkness. A single bottle of water sat crooked behind the glass, as though someone had almost bought it and changed their mind at the last second.

For some reason, he found that depressing.

Maybe he was tired.

Maybe everything looked depressing after midnight.

The station clock showed 12:11 AM when he heard footsteps.

Slow footsteps.

Not hurried.

Not cautious.

Just steady.

Riven looked up.

An old woman was making her way along the platform with her hands buried deep inside the pockets of a heavy wool coat. The coat seemed a size too large for her, hanging loosely from her shoulders as she walked. There was nothing remarkable about her appearance, yet something about her immediately drew his attention.

Perhaps it was because nobody came to a railway station at this hour unless they had a reason.

The woman didn't look lost.

She didn't look hurried.

She walked with the quiet confidence of someone who knew exactly where she was going.

Which was strange.

Because there was nowhere to go.

The station was closed. The tracks were empty. The last train had departed hours ago.

Yet she continued walking toward him.

Riven watched her approach, expecting her to pass by without a second glance. Instead, she stopped beside his bench and stood there for a moment, looking out across the tracks. The wind tugged gently at the edge of her coat while rain clouds rolled silently overhead.

Then she sat down.

The bench creaked beneath the added weight before settling once more into silence.

People occasionally sat beside strangers in railway stations. Normally he wouldn't have given it a second thought. What caught his attention wasn't the woman's presence but her comfort. Most people felt the need to fill silence with something. Small talk. Questions. Complaints about the weather.

This woman seemed perfectly content to sit there and watch the tracks.

As though she had been doing it for years.

A minute passed.

Then another.

Neither of them spoke.

The station clock continued ticking overhead while the wind wandered lazily through the empty platform. Somewhere in the darkness, thunder rumbled faintly.

The old woman smiled.

Not at him.

At the tracks.

And for reasons Riven couldn't explain, that unsettled him more than if she had stared directly into his eyes.



Riven shifted slightly on the bench and glanced toward her again. Up close, she looked older than he had first thought. Deep lines crossed her face, and strands of silver hair had escaped from beneath the hood of her coat. Yet there was nothing fragile about her. She sat with her hands resting comfortably in her lap, her gaze fixed on the rails disappearing into the darkness as though she expected something to emerge from it.

He followed her gaze. There was nothing there. Just tracks, darkness, and the same empty horizon he had been staring at for years. A drop of rain struck the platform roof overhead, then another. The sound spread slowly across the station, a scattered rhythm of water against metal. Neither of them reacted to it.

Riven cleared his throat. "Bad weather for a midnight walk."

The words left his mouth before he could stop them. He wasn't sure why he had spoken. Perhaps the silence had finally become too heavy. Perhaps he simply wanted proof that she was real.

The old woman smiled faintly. "I've walked through worse."